

Marketing Report: SKUBU



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Executive Summary

SKUBU is an innovative South African retail start up that positions itself as, “The world’s first fully automated IoT-enabled, low-cost, smart refill store” (Council for Scientific and Industrial Research, n.d.). SKUBU is rooted in the mission of providing affordable and dignified access to essential goods across South Africa whilst reducing the use of single-use plastics in low income communities nationwide (Vuka, 2025). Their fundamental business objectives are grounded in their core aims which include: affordability, environmental sustainability, inclusive retail access, technological innovation and scalability (Vuka, 2025). This report has identified key marketing challenges and proposes a data-informed marketing strategy that both strengthens SKUBU’s current positioning and expands on their current target demographic as a means to further their fundamental business objectives.

Key Problems and Findings:

Our report has identified Low Brand Awareness (or Salience) as well as the age and category of SKUBU as contributing marketing challenges. Utilising Keller’s Brand Equity Pyramid (1993) as a framework, SKUBU’s marketing challenges include the following:

1. **Brand Visibility:** SKUBU currently lacks brand awareness and salience amongst the general South African public. This is due to its limited visibility, both offline and online.
2. **Consumer Scepticism:** Due to the age and nature of SKUBU’s business model, the company faces high consumer scepticism as well as the challenge of adapting current consumer behavior that is traditionally oriented around pre-packaged retail offerings (Verplanken & Roy, 2016).

Strategic Recommendations

To contrast the identified challenges our marketing strategy proposes the following:

1. **Offline Activations:** Implement highly visible and tangible brand activations that establish physical salience.

2. Phased SMART Objectives: Execute a phased roadmap that is focused on expanding its target consumer to the youth, broadening its brand awareness and identity as well as promoting sustainable consumption.
3. Digital Integration: develop and implement social media strategy geared towards building community-led trust, education and strengthening its “top -of mind” awareness.

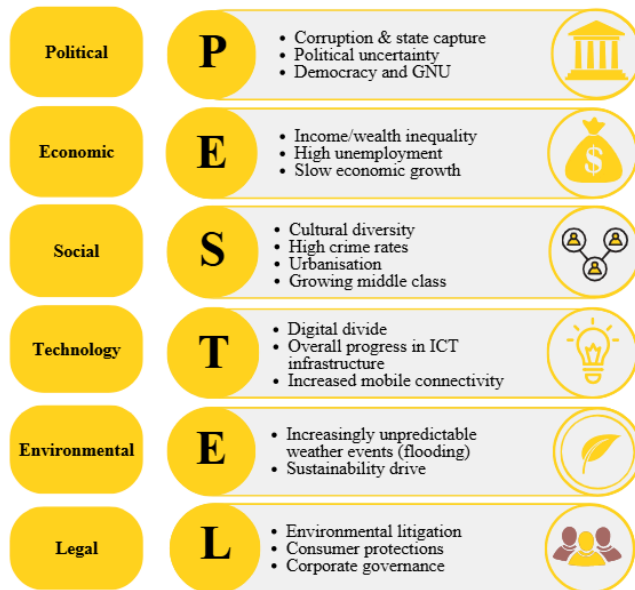
We believe our proposed marketing strategy and implementation plan for SKUBU has optimal potential to broaden its current positioning and ultimately usher the company into reaching its business objectives.

Situational Analysis

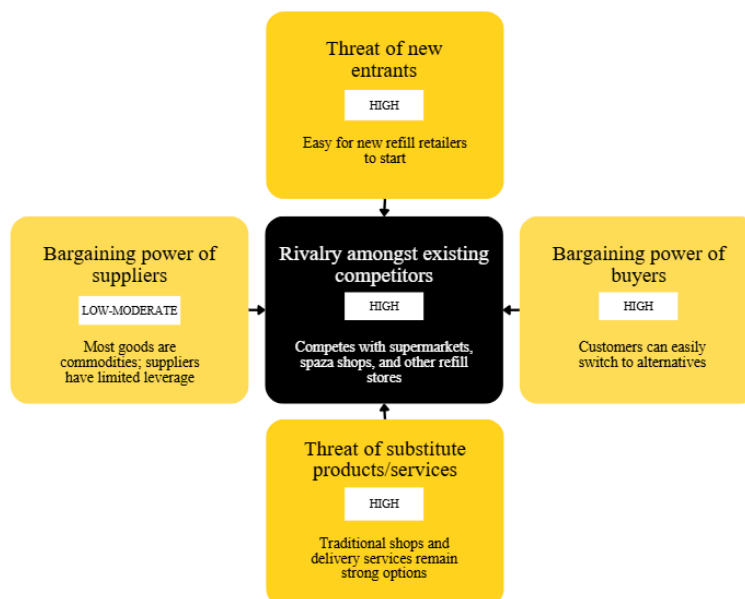
External Analysis

PESTEL Analysis (Makos, 2024).

Below is a PESTEL analysis for Skubu followed by Porter's 5 Forces and SWOT Analysis:



B. Porter's 5 Forces:



C. SWOT Analysis

Helpful	Harmful
Strengths 1. Affordable essentials Eliminates packaging and brand premiums leading to lower prices for budget-conscious households 2. Automated refill technology IoT enabled smart dispensers create a hygienic, efficient experience 3. Sustainability-driven model Eliminates single-use packaging and supports circular economy practices	Weaknesses 1. Limited footprint Few locations (2) limits scale and brand visibility 2. Customer adoption friction Technology may deter first-time or less tech-comfortable users, increased need to educate consumers 3. Inconsistent social media usage and brand messaging
Opportunities - Youth Market Focus 1. Campus expansions Launch micro refill kiosks at Wits, UJ Soweto, UP Mamelodi, and TUT Soshanguve to capture high-density student demand 2. Gen-Z sustainability appeal Position SKUBU as the affordable, eco-conscious alternative for budget-driven students	Threats 1. Retail Giants Supermarkets can replicate refill models at scale 2. Price wars Competitors can undercut prices in sensitive markets 3. Refill Rivals

Internal Environmental Analysis

Company Overview

SKUBU is South Africa's first fully automated, IoT-enabled, low-cost smart refill store, launched in 2025 (Skubu, 2025). The business operates on an innovative model where customers bring their own containers to refill essential household products, paying only for the product, not the packaging (De Jongh, 2025). This positions Skubu as a pioneer in a new retail category within the South African market. Skubu is backed by a partnership between Transform (an impact accelerator involving Unilever, the UK Government, and EY) and local operator Sonke (Transform, 2024). This provides the business with established supply chain access and impact-focused resources.

1. **Financial Operations:** SKUBU is supported by Transform and Sonke. This provides financial stability and access to impact investment networks (Transform, 2024). They experience lower operating expenses due to automation and the elimination of packaging costs. This enables its competitive pricing (De Jongh, 2025). The startup

has strong scalability potential as the business model is designed for expansion across Southern Africa, indicating its financial planning for growth.

2. **Technological Resources:** SKUBU's IoT-Enabled fully automated refill system ensures hygiene, standardisation and reliability (Sonke Retail, 2025). As a first-of-its-kind concept in South Africa, they hold a technological advantage over traditional retailers and spaza shops. IoT systems can potentially track usage patterns, inventory needs and customer preferences for future optimisation (Sonke Retail, 2025).
3. **Physical Resources:** Current stores are placed in high foot-traffic community areas within urban townships. Unlike large supermarkets, SKUBU does not require extensive retail space, allowing for flexible and accessible location choices. The pilot operation in Diepsloot, Gauteng, serves as a real-world testing ground and proof of concept.
4. **Operational Capabilities:** Automated dispensing ensures consistent quality and hygiene standards (Sonke Retail, 2025). Partnership with Unilever (via Transform) provides access to established FMCG supply chains for products like Sunlight and Handy Andy (Transform, 2024). Automation and the no-packaging model reduce overheads compared to traditional retailers (De Jongh, 2025).
5. **Weaknesses:** Due to SKUBU being a new market entrant, its limited operational history means systems are still being refined. Additionally, While designed for scale, the model is still in its early stages and requires proof of replicability.
6. **Brand and Reputation:** With regards to brand awareness, SKUBU gained prominence through a viral TikTok video, which introduced the brand to a wider audience. Yet, beyond this viral moment, there is restrained emphasis on intentional digital marketing across platforms like Instagram, X (Twitter) and TikTok. As a new entrant (2025), brand equity is still in its infancy and requires deliberate nurturing.

1. Customer Analysis

Primary Customer Segment: Low-Income Township Consumers

Key characteristics:

- a. Demographics: SASSA grant recipients aged 45-60, who live in townships or peri-urban areas, often support multigenerational households and have limited disposable income.
- b. Behavioural Traits: highly price sensitive, willing to switch brands for lower prices, prioritise basic necessities over brand loyalty
- c. Needs & Pain Points: Cannot consistently afford essential household products, need lower prices and flexible quantities, often buy in small amounts due to cash flow constraints.
- d. Value Skubu Provides: Lower product prices (e.g., Omo 500g: R14.99 vs R26.99 at supermarkets), refill model allows customers to buy only what they need, reduces packaging cost and waste.

Key Buying Drivers: price savings, convenience, access to essential goods, ability to buy small quantities.

Customer Awareness Problem

A major challenge revealed in the research: A large portion of the target market does not know of SKUBU's existence. With regards to discovery sources, it is mainly social media and word of mouth. There is minimal awareness via traditional channels. This indicates a marketing communication gap rather than a demand problem.

Core Value Proposition

Skubu's value proposition rests on three pillars:

1. Affordable essentials
2. Automated refill technology
3. Sustainable consumption model
4. This allows the company to compete on price and environmental impact simultaneously.

Competitive Advantage

1. Price Leadership: Due to customers paying only for the product and not packaging, SKUBU can offer significantly lower prices. For example at a supermarket a consumer would pay R26.99 whereas they would pay R14.99 at SKUBU for the same product.
2. Technology Advantage: The IoT-enabled refill stations automate dispensing and inventory management. Benefits include: reduced operational costs, faster transactions, scalable model
3. Sustainability Positioning: Reduced plastic packaging: Reusable containers: Appeals to environmentally conscious consumers.

Competitors Analysis:

Direct competitors of Skubu

SmartFill:

A new grocery trend, powered by Smartfill dispensers, is transforming the way locals buy their daily essentials and doing so at prices up to 50% cheaper than major supermarket chains like Shoprite, Pick n Pay, and Checkers (Nikita, 2025). Smartfill refill dispensers in Tembisa spazas let shoppers buy small amounts of rice, oil and washing powder for as little as R2 (Scrolla, 2025). The system cuts costs by up to 50%, reduces plastic waste and helps township spaza shops grow their businesses (Scrolla, 2025).

Gcwalisa:

A grocery refill dispensary outlet in Alexandra, Johannesburg (Bester, 2022). Gcwalisa uses a weigh-and-pay trading model, allowing consumers to buy a selection of basic foodstuffs for as little as R5 (Bester, 2022). For example, customers can get 250g mealie meal for as little as R4 or 250ml cooking oil for R12 (Bester, 2022). To qualify for these low prices, the customer needs to bring their own container/jar or they can purchase a reusable jar from Gcwalisa (Bester, 2022).



Indirect competitors

The competitors listed below are Skubu's indirect competitors as Skubu isn't attempting to duplicate the structure of these large supermarkets. They are competing in terms of attaining customer loyalty and profit. They are traditional retailers. Traditional retail trade is the selling of goods within local communities, through informal channels such as open-air markets, roadside stalls, and neighbourhood shops (Frontline Group, n.d.). Unlike formal retail, which operates within structured frameworks and commercial institutions, traditional retail thrives on personal interactions and cultural nuances (Frontline Group, n.d.).

- *Pick n Pay*: The Pick n Pay Group is a retail business in the fast-moving consumer goods industry (MBA Skool Team in Lifestyle and Retail category, n.d.). Pick n Pay prides itself in attaining customer loyalty because of its strong focus on good service (MBA Skool Team in Lifestyle and Retail category, n.d.).
- *Shoprite*: Shoprite Holdings is a South African-based company that was founded in 1979. It is one of the largest food retailers in Africa, and offers a wide range of products and services, ranging from groceries, to medicines, to clothing and electronics (Shoprite SWOT analysis and Strategic Overview, n.d.) The company is committed to providing customers with quality and affordable products, as well as excellent customer service (Shoprite SWOT analysis and Strategic Overview, n.d.)
- *Usave*: Usave is a discount grocery store brand that operates under the Shoprite Group. Established in 2001, the first Usave store opened in Stellenbosch, Western Cape (Shoprite, n.d.; Usave, n.d.). The brand is designed to cater to lower-income consumers by offering a limited assortment of essential goods at competitive prices (Shoprite, n.d.; Usave, n.d.). The philosophy behind Usave is encapsulated in its slogan: "When we save, Usave" (Shoprite, n.d.; Usave, n.d.)

These businesses sell pre-packaged goods whereas Skubu does not have pre-packaged goods (Frontline Group, n.d.). These organisations generate profit through promotion, bulk procurement, and loyalty programs (Frontline Group, n.d.).

The 7Ps Marketing Mix: SKUBU

1. Product

In marketing, a product is anything that can be offered to a market for attention, acquisition, or use to satisfy a want or need (Kotler & Armstrong, 2011). SKUBU offers automated refill services for a range of household essentials, including: maize meal, rice, cooking oil, sugar, cleaning liquids, soaps, and detergents. At the core benefit level, the company provides affordable and dignified access to daily necessities. The actual product consists of IoT-enabled automated refill stations that dispense goods by weight or volume. The augmented product includes the environmental benefit of reducing plastic waste and the social credibility gained through partnerships with the CSIR and DSTI (CSIR, n.d.). A key challenge is that SKUBU loses brand visibility once products leave the store due to the refill model removing branded packaging. To address this, the brand could introduce reusable branded containers or a digital loyalty programme that keeps the brand connected to customers beyond the point of purchase.

2. Price

Price is the amount of money charged for a product or service, or the sum of all values that consumers exchange for the benefits of having or using the product (Kotler & Armstrong, 2011). SKUBU uses a value-based pricing strategy, meaning prices are set based on what customers perceive as good value rather than simply covering costs. This is supported by competitive pricing, as it deliberately positions itself below formal retailers. For example, maize meal is sold at R9 per kilogram compared to R20 in supermarkets, representing a 55% saving (VUKA Group, 2025). Skubu's pricing advantages include no packaging costs and lower operating expenses due to automation. Marketing communication should emphasise three key messages: "Pay only for what you use" – highlighting the fairness and flexibility of the model; cost savings over time for regular purchases; and overall value for money, particularly for low-income households managing tight budgets.

3. Place

Place refers to all company activities that make the product available to target consumers (Kotler & Armstrong, 2011). Skubu's distribution strategy focuses on selective placement in high-traffic, accessible locations. Current and planned sites include: township communities such as Diepsloot; areas where residents rely on walking rather than private transport; and near student accommodation and densely populated residential areas. Like spaza shops, Skubu offers spatial convenience by being close to customers and easily accessible for daily, top-up purchases. However, unlike formal supermarkets that require large retail spaces, Skubu's compact automated stations can operate in smaller, cost-effective locations. This flexibility supports SKUBU's goal of scaling from 2 to over 30 stores across Southern Africa (VUKA Group, 2025).

4. Promotion

Promotion refers to activities that communicate the merits of a product and persuade target customers to buy it (Kotler & Armstrong, 2011). Due to the refill concept being new to many consumers, Skubu's promotional strategy focuses on education and awareness using a blend of above-the-line and below-the-line tactics. Key promotional activities include: influencer marketing, as seen in the viral TikTok campaign where local influencer @yungearn created authentic content that built trust and drove discovery (Fast Company SA, 2026); founder communication, with Ebenezer de Jongh posting a personal response video that humanised the brand and explained its mission; public relations, leveraging the CSIR and DSTI partnership to add credibility and position Skubu as a socially responsible innovation (CSIR, n.d.); and point-of-sale materials, with clear signage at SKUBU locations guiding first-time users and communicating savings and environmental benefits. The communication objectives are to inform consumers about how the system works, build trust in the hygiene and reliability of the automated process, and reinforce the brand's core values of affordability, sustainability, and dignity.

5. People

In services marketing, people are all human actors who play a part in service delivery and influence the buyer's perceptions (Khan, 2014). In a service-based retail model, the people element is critical to customer experience and trust building. Although the refill process is automated, staff are still needed for: on-site assistance to help first-time users navigate the

system; technical support for the IoT-enabled machines; and community engagement to build local relationships. Staff should be trained to project a helpful and professional image that builds customer confidence, communicate the environmental and cost-saving benefits of the Skubu model, and handle queries and technical issues promptly. Additionally, the visible involvement of the founder in social media content adds a human face to the brand, building emotional connection and trust with the community. This is essential in township markets where personal relationships and word-of-mouth carry significant weight (Fast Company SA, 2026).

6. Process

Process refers to the procedures, mechanisms, and flow of activities by which the service is delivered (Khan, 2014). The refill process works as follows: customers bring their own clean container to a SKUBU store; select the desired product; the automated machine dispenses the exact quantity requested; customers pay based on weight or volume; and the IoT-enabled system tracks stock levels and sales data in real-time (CSIR, n.d.). Process advantages include: speed, as automation makes transactions quick; accuracy, with standardised dispensing ensuring consistency; hygiene, as the closed system reduces human contact with food products; and traceability, with back-end software providing full visibility of stock movement from receipt to sale (CSIR, n.d.). A clear service recovery process must also be in place for handling machine malfunctions or customer complaints promptly to maintain trust.

7. Physical Evidence

Physical evidence is the environment in which the service is delivered and any tangible components that facilitate performance or communication of the service (Khan, 2014). This is especially important for SKUBU, as the product itself leaves no branded packaging behind. Key physical evidence elements include: the store environment, with clean, well-maintained machines signalling reliability and hygiene, bright and welcoming storefronts attracting foot traffic, and clear signage explaining how the system works and highlighting price savings; branding elements, with SKUBU branding on machines and signage reinforcing brand identity, and visual materials communicating the core messages of affordability, sustainability, and community focus; community presence, with store locations in the heart of communities serving as physical proof of SKUBU's commitment to serving local residents, as visibility and accessibility build trust over time; and online presence, with social media

content including videos of real customers using the stores serving as virtual physical evidence, encouraging others to try the system (Fast Company SA, 2026).

Marketing Challenges:

1. New to Market and Category:

A marketing challenge that Skubu faces is its infancy in the South African market. Having launched in 2025, the brand awareness of the company is limited. SKUBU positions itself as, “the world’s first fully automated IoT-enabled, low-cost,smart refill store” (Council for Scientific and Industrial Research, n.d.). This demonstrates that it acts first in both category and retail offering. As it is a first in a new category, consumers lack previous experience with this consumer offering. Additionally, Skubu faces a potential marketing challenge of consumers associating its category offering “refillable goods” with low quality (Keller, 1993). Thus, Skubu is challenged with needing to counter consumer skepticism and consumers’ assumption of “perceived risk” due to the age and nature of the company’s business model.

2. Brand Awareness:

A pertinent marketing challenge faced by Skubu is its limited brand awareness. Through Keller’s Brand Equity Model, Skubu can be understood as having low brand salience, and thus, operating at the lowest level of Keller’s Pyramid (Keller, 1993). This suggests that their primary challenge resides in not being ‘top of mind’ or occupying any mental space of consumers when they engage in decision-making for purchasing relevant consumer goods (Keller, 1993). Their low brand salience, or awareness, can be attributed to its limited brand visibility both online and offline. Skubu’s limited physical salience (visibility in real-life on things such as large posters, billboards, street signages or adverts in high foot traffic areas) as well as its limited digital footprint across all social media platforms (such as Tiktok, Instagram and X) contributes to its lack of mental availability in its current consumer market as well as our suggested target market. This is in direct contrast to competitive brands such as Shoprite or USave. Their low brand salience and awareness is highlighted as a marketing challenge as it currently hampers growth for Skubu’s brand equity, awareness and ultimately position in the South African retail-adjacent industry (Skubu, 2025).

Marketing Strategy

Strategic Objectives

The overall objective of the marketing strategy is to increase SKUBU's brand awareness and expand its customer base. This, while reinforcing its positioning as a convenient and affordable refill grocery store. Additionally, the strategy aims to strengthen SKUBU's positioning as a sustainable retail alternative by promoting the environmental benefits of refill based purchasing. It is to note that our proposed SMART Marketing Objectives and implementation plan have been informed by market research we have conducted (See Appendix A).

SMART Marketing Objectives

1. Increase brand awareness:

The brand aims to increase brand awareness among consumers aged 18–35 in targeted tertiary and shopping mall areas by 50 percent within 2 years through targeted digital marketing campaigns and in-store promotional activities.

2. Attract younger consumers:

To increase the number of customers aged 18–35 by 50 percent within 2 years while maintaining engagement with the existing price sensitive customer segment through consistent value based messaging.

3. Strengthen brand identity:

To develop and implement a clear brand identity, including a slogan and consistent messaging framework, within two months in order to reduce brand confusion and improve brand recognition among potential customers.

4. Promote sustainable consumption:

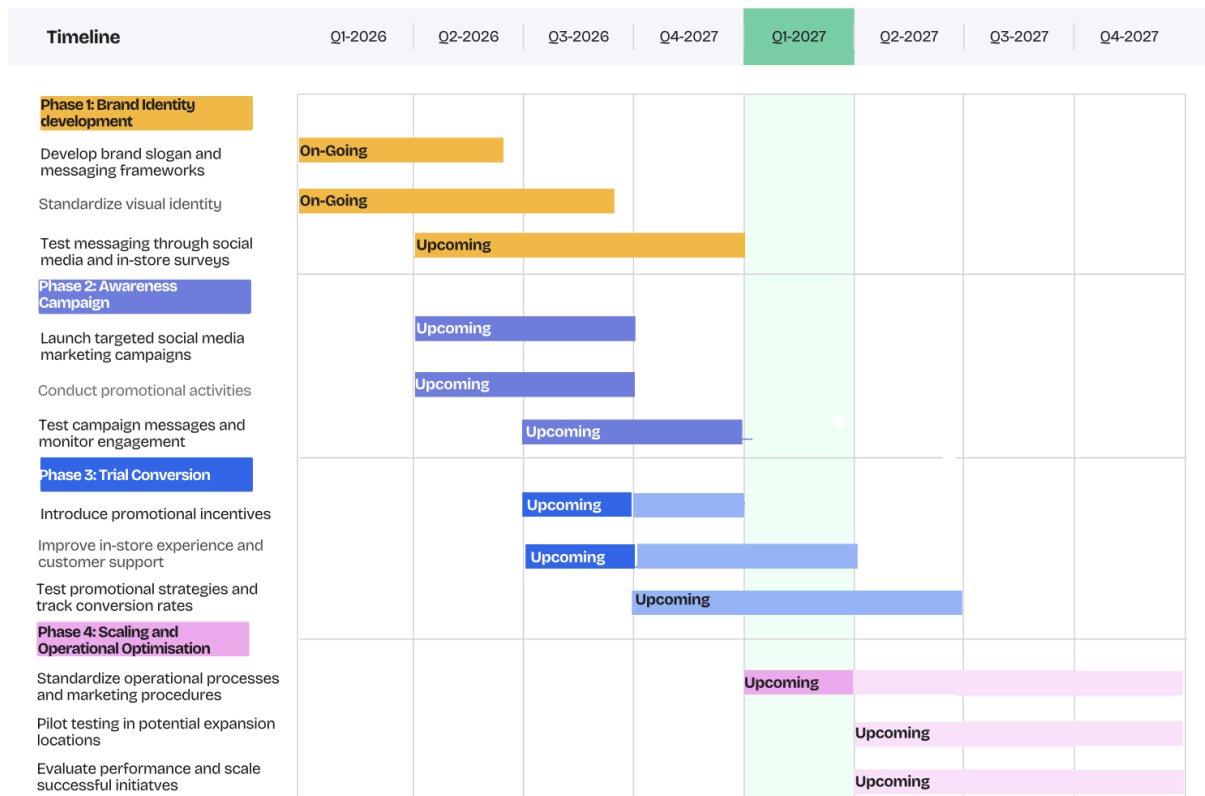
To increase consumer awareness of the environmental benefits of refill based purchasing by integrating sustainability focused messaging into marketing communications. This, with the aim of increasing trial purchases of refill products by 40 percent within 2 years.

5. Communicate value through sustainability marketing:

Position SKUBU as both a cost effective and environmentally responsible retail option by highlighting reduced packaging waste and responsible consumption practices across marketing channels. This objective supports the growing importance of sustainability in consumer decision making and reinforces the brand's long term positioning.

Implementation Roadmap

Marketing Strategy Implementation Gantt Chart



Phase 1: Brand Identity Development (1 Year)

The first phase focuses on clarifying SKUBU's brand identity in order to reduce customer confusion and strengthen brand recognition. During this stage, a clear slogan and consistent messaging framework should be developed in order to communicate the brand's value proposition of affordability and convenience. Visual identity elements such as packaging and digital content should also be standardized to ensure consistency across all customer touchpoints. Staff training should be implemented to ensure employees are able to clearly communicate the brand positioning and assist customers in understanding the refill purchasing model. SKUBU should test alternative slogan and messaging options through social media campaigns and short in-store surveys in order to ensure that branding decisions are effective. Customer feedback can be collected through QR code surveys or direct interaction with staff. These testing mechanisms allow the company to evaluate which messaging resonates most strongly with consumers. The performance during this phase can be evaluated through measurable indicators such as improvements in brand recognition in follow up surveys, social media engagement rates and the number of customer responses

collected. Data collected during this stage will inform further adjustments to brand communication and positioning.

Phase 2: Awareness Campaign (1 Year)

The second phase focuses on increasing brand awareness among potential customers who are currently unfamiliar with SKUBU. Targeted marketing campaigns should be implemented primarily through social media platforms, as the research indicates that digital channels are a key source of brand discovery. Marketing efforts should focus particularly on areas with high concentrations of the target market, such as tertiary campuses and shopping malls.

This phase can include promotional activities such as in store demonstrations, refill product sampling and partnerships with student ambassadors. This is to increase visibility and encourage engagement. These activities help potential customers understand the refill model and experience the value proposition directly. An experimental approach should be used when designing promotional messages. The campaigns which emphasize affordability, sustainability and convenience can be tested simultaneously to examine which message generates the strongest customer response. Performance can be measured through metrics such as increases in brand awareness, growth in store foot traffic and digital reach in the targeted geographic areas.

Phase 3: Trial Conversion (1 Year)

The objective of the third phase is to convert interested consumers into first time customers. Promotional initiatives such as introductory discounts and trial incentives can be introduced to reduce the perceived risk of trying a new retail concept. Moreover, clear in store communication should also highlight the cost savings associated with refill purchasing compared with traditional supermarket purchases. Operational improvements are also important during this phase. The store layout, cleanliness and customer service standards should be strengthened in order to create a positive shopping experience that encourages repeat visits. Staff training should be expanded to focus on assisting customers who are unfamiliar with automated or refill based purchasing systems.

Two different promotional strategies can be tested to determine which approach generates the highest conversion rates. SKUBU could compare the effectiveness of a price discount incentive with a loyalty based reward system. Key performance indicators include the

number of new customers acquired, conversion rates from store visits to purchases and overall customer satisfaction levels.

Phase 4: Scaling and Operational Optimisation (2 Years)

The final phase focuses on refining successful initiatives and preparing the business model for expansion. At this stage, operational processes should be documented and standardized in order to create consistent store experiences and support potential franchise development. Standard operating procedures for marketing activities, store layout, customer service and refill processes should be formalized. Testing can also be extended to new locations, particularly in areas identified through research as attractive for the target market. This includes tertiary and shopping malls. Pilot testing in new locations allows the company to evaluate demand, operational efficiency and customer experience before committing to larger scale expansion. The performance during this stage can be measured through indicators such as revenue growth, customer retention rates and the identification of viable expansion locations. Successful strategies identified in earlier phases can be scaled while less effective approaches can be refined or replaced.

Moreover, scaling and operational optimisation are long term. The brand has a goal of reaching 30 stores across South Africa by the end of 2027. It is however advisable to scale more sustainably to ensure consistency in brand value and quality. The goal of 30 stores can be achieved in 5 years.

SKUBU operates as a startup therefore the implementation process should be viewed as agile rather than strictly linear. The insights gained during later phases may require the business to revisit earlier stages in order to refine brand messaging, marketing tactics or operational processes. This agile approach enables continuous learning and adaptation. This is essential for startups operating in new and emerging and uncertain market environments.

Marketing Tactics: Skubu

When developing marketing tactics, the marketing mix (also known as the 4Ps) is an essential framework. It ensures that a brand's high-level strategy is effectively translated into action (Khan, 2014). Without it, a marketing plan remains just an idea.

The marketing mix is important for three main reasons:

- a) It gives the marketer a set of controllable tools to work with. These tools; Product, Price, Place, and Promotion are what you adjust to create the desired response in the target market.
- b) It forces the company to deliver on its value proposition. For example, Skubu's promise of "affordability and sustainability" is not just a slogan. It is delivered through tangible tactics: a product innovation (automated refill stations), a price strategy (55% cost savings), a place decision (location in Diepsloot), and a promotion strategy (viral influencer marketing) (Fast Company, 2026; CSIR, n.d.).
- c) It ensures integration and consistency. When all four elements are aligned, the brand message is clear and credible. This builds brand equity and creates a sustainable competitive advantage (Khan, 2014).

In sum, the marketing mix is the bridge between strategy and execution. It turns customer insights into real-world tactics that drive sales and build customer relationships.

1. Product

SKUBU's core offering is an automated refill service for essential household products. The "product" is a combination of goods and experience (De Jongh, 2025).

Key Offerings:

- Refill stations for: Maize meal, rice, sugar, cooking oil, detergents, soaps, cleaning liquids (including Unilever brands like Sunlight and Handy Andy) (Transform, 2024).
- 2.IoT-enabled automated dispensers ensuring hygiene, accuracy and standardization (Sonke Retail, 2025)
- A sustainable alternative that eliminates single-use plastic packaging (CSIR, 2025)

Tactical Considerations:

1. *Product Range Expansion:* Introduce additional high-demand dry goods and cleaning products based on community feedback. Currently SKUBU operates with approximately 20 SKUs which some industry observers note is a tight range (Pabst, 2025).
2. *Quality Assurance:* Regular maintenance and calibration of dispensers to ensure consistent portioning and hygiene (Sonke Retail, 2025).

3. *Own-Container Model*: Encourage reuse while offering low-cost reusable containers for first-time or unprepared customers.

2. Price

SKUBU uses a value-based and competitive pricing strategy that emphasizes affordability and transparency (De Jongh, 2025).

Pricing Tactics:

- Pay-Only-for-Product Model: No packaging costs passed to consumers (Skubu, 2025).
- Price Comparison Marketing: In-store signage and social media content showing price comparisons with supermarkets (e.g., maize meal at R9/kg vs. R20 at traditional retailers) (Business Tech, 2025).
- Tiered Pricing: Lower unit prices for larger refill volumes to encourage bulk purchasing among households. Some observers note this creates an incentive to "pantry-load" which may partially defeat the purpose of daily purchasing for low-income households (Pabst, 2025).
- Promotional Launch Pricing: Introductory discounts to encourage trial and build initial customer traffic.
- Communication Focus: "Pay only for what you need" (De Jongh, 2025), "Up to 50% cheaper than supermarkets" (CSIR, 2025), "No packaging, no markup" (Skubu, 2025)

3. Place (Distribution)

SKUBU's placement strategy focuses on accessibility and community integration (Sonke Retail, 2025).

Placement Tactics:

- High Foot-Traffic Locations: Stores situated in: Township and peri-urban residential areas such as Diepsloot, near student accommodations and taxi ranks and community hubs with easy walking access.
- Compact Store Format: A small store footprint allows for flexible placement in areas where large retailers cannot operate (Supermarket & Retailer, 2025).
- Pilot Store: Diepsloot, Gauteng serves as a test site for refining operations before scaling (CSIR, 2025).

- Future Expansion: Planned rollout across Southern Africa, targeting underserved communities (Skubu, 2025).
- Competitive Advantage:
- Unlike supermarkets, Skubu does not require large retail space or parking lots (Joburg ETC, 2025)
- Mirrors the accessibility of spaza shops while offering a more structured, reliable experience

4. Promotion

Promotion tactics must focus on education, awareness and trust-building, as the refill model is new to most South African consumers (Fast Company, 2026).

Promotional Tactics:

A. Above-the-Line (ATL)

- Community Radio Ads: Local radio stations in township areas to build brand recognition (ECR, 2025)
- Print Media: Posters and flyers distributed in targeted communities

B. Below-the-Line (BTL)

- In-Store Signage: Clear, multilingual instructions explaining how the refill process works (Skubu, 2025)
- Demonstration Days: On-site staff to guide first-time users through the process and answer questions
- Loyalty Program: Digital or card-based system rewarding repeat customers (e.g., "Buy 10 refills, get 1 free")

C. Digital Marketing

- Social Media Content: Regular posts on TikTok, Instagram and Facebook showcasing:
- Customer testimonials (Fast Company, 2026)
- Price comparisons (Business Tech, 2025)
- Educational videos on how to use the dispensers
- Influencer Partnerships: Collaborate with community-based influencers and content creators (like the original viral video) to demonstrate the experience authentically (Fast Company, 2026).
- WhatsApp Community Groups: Build local WhatsApp groups for updates, promotions and customer feedback

D. Word-of-Mouth

- Encourage satisfied customers to share their savings with friends and family (Fast Company, 2026)
- Referral discounts for bringing new customers

5. People

People are critical to Skubu's success, especially in building trust within communities (Sonke Retail, 2025).

Tactics:

- *Community Ambassadors:* Hire locally to staff locations, ensuring cultural alignment and trust (Joburg ETC, 2025)
- *Training Programs:* Train staff working within the business
- Educate customers on the refill process
- Address hygiene and quality concerns
- Provide excellent, friendly service
- *Customer Engagement:* Staff encouraged to build relationships with regular customers, mirroring the spaza shop experience

6. Process

The process must be simple, fast and reliable to encourage repeat usage (Sonke Retail, 2025).

Process Tactics:

- *Step-by-Step Instructions:* Clear signage at each dispenser (in multiple languages) (Skubu, 2025)
- *Automated Dispensing:* IoT technology ensures accurate measurement and payment (CSIR, 2025)
- *Payment Options:* Accept cash and digital payments. Currently Skubu operates on a card-based system where cash must be loaded onto a card first, which some customers find adds an extra step (Pabst, 2025).
- *Hygiene Protocols:* Regular cleaning schedules for dispensers and visible sanitation stations (Sonke Retail, 2025)
- *Feedback Mechanism:* Simple system (e.g., QR code) for customers to report issues or suggest improvements

7. Physical Evidence

Since Skubu's product is consumed elsewhere, the physical environment must reinforce trust, quality and brand identity (Skubu, 2025).

Physical Evidence Tactics:

- *Clean, Modern Store Design:* Bright, well-maintained locations that contrast with informal trading spaces (Joburg ETC, 2025)
- *Branded Elements:* Consistent use of Skubu colors, logos and messaging throughout the store
- *Packaging Alternatives:* While customers bring their own containers, offer affordable, reusable Skubu-branded containers for those who need them (extending brand visibility into homes)
- *Digital Screens:* Display prices, savings comparisons and educational content in-store
- *Uniforms:* Staff wear clean, branded aprons or T-shirts to project professionalism.

Growth Strategy for Skubu

Market penetration would be the suitable growth strategy for SKUBU. Market penetration involves making more sales without changing its original product. Market penetration is the simplest and first option for growth in most companies (Sajjad Hussain, 2013). They are in a market with a present or on hand product, at present (Sajjad Hussain, 2013). Market penetration is an attempt to increase company sales without leaving the original product market strategy at the cost of rivals in the market (Sajjad Hussain, 2013).

SKUBU is a new organisation. They have entered an existing market and have yet to reach their potential (Lindeque, 2026). The implementation of market penetration as their growth strategy, will assist in increasing their sales without changing its original products (Philip Kotler, 2012). This growth strategy will promote visibility of the business within the market they are in, retain current consumers, attract new consumers within the market and increase their market share (Philip Kotler, 2012). They can retain current customers and attract new ones with the use of promotions, discounts, loyalty programs.

Measure and Evaluations

To evaluate the efficacy of our proposed marketing strategy, SKUBU will track these key performance indicators (KPIs). The first key performance indicator we will measure is brand awareness, which shows how many people know about the brand (Philip Kotler, 2012). This is where the business aims to boost brand visibility in order to stay relevant (Philip Kotler, 2012).

The second key performance indicator we will measure is new customer acquisition (Philip Kotler, 2012) , which tells us how many people are trying SKUBU for the first time. As mentioned in our market strategy, primary research reveals a clear market opportunity. 76% of respondents have never heard of SKUBU, representing significant untapped market potential for brand awareness campaigns.

The third key performance indicator we will evaluate is retained and returning customers. This will indicate the extent to which consumers are satisfied with SKUBU and willingly return to the store as opposed to shopping at the competitors (Philip Kotler, 2012).

The fourth key performance indicator we will evaluate is market share growth. In this section we will be tracking SKUBU's penetration in the refill retail market (Sajjad Hussain, 2013). Our key focus will be on these KPIs we are aiming to achieve in order to boost awareness around the brand and increase their customer base in order to increase the company's market share (Sajjad Hussain, 2013).

Conclusion

In conclusion, SKUBU is a cutting edge, technologically-savvy introduction into the South African retail landscape. However, this report has highlighted that its technological innovation alone is insufficient to guarantee the business success. Rather, the implementation of data-driven marketing strategy has the potential to drive the company into greater success. From the outset, the situational analysis for SKUBU was provided as a means to contextualise its business model and current marketing strategy. We then identified that key marketing challenges for SKUBU were rooted in its low brand salience (awareness), partly due to the company's age and category of operation. As a means to address these challenges we proposed a data informed marketing strategy and implementation plan that could ultimately transcend this startup from being a niche 'low cost' brand with low brand salience to one with an established brand equity associated with dignity, sustainability and community-centricity. The implementation of offline activations as well as an intentional social media strategy, were some of the suggested marketing tactics the company should implement as means to strengthen its brand awareness and drive SKUBU closer to its fundamental business objectives.

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Appendix

Appendix A: Research Questions

Skubu market research:

1. Awareness (Do they know you?)
2. Interest / demand (Would they buy?)
3. Shopping behavior (Where would they go?)
4. Brand perception (Does it feel approachable/trustworthy?)
5. Positioning vs competitors

SECTION 1: Target Market (demographics)

Gender: (As gender)

- Male
- Female
- Do not wish to specify

Age: (As age)

- 17 or less
- 18-24
- 25-30
- 31-40
- 41-50
- 51-60
- More than 60

Occupation: (As occupation)

- Student
- Unemployed
- Working Professional (full time)
- Working professional (part time)
- Freelancer
- Self employed

Monthly income range: (as monthly_income)

- Less than 1000
- 1000-2500
- 2500-5000
- 5000-10000
- 10000-20000
- More than 20000

SECTION 2: Brand Awareness

Unaided Awareness:

When you think of stores that sell non perishable goods (eg. Maize, washing powder, oil etc), which brands come to mind?

Aided Awareness

Have you heard of Skubu? (As skubu_awareness)

- Yes
- Not
- Not sure

If yes:

How did you hear about us? (As skubu_discovery_channel)

- Social media
- Word of mouth
- Walked past store
- Online search
- Event/pop-up
- Other: _____

SECTION 2: Interest & Purchase Intent

How likely would you be to shop at a store that offers non-perishables in your desired quantity? (As custom_quantity_interest)

- Very likely
- Somewhat likely
- Neutral
- Unlikely
- Very unlikely

What would make you most interested in shopping there? (As interest_factors)

- Price
- Quality
- Convenience
- Unique products
- Ethical/sustainable
- Brand reputation
- Trendy/aesthetic
- Other: _____

How often do you buy (product category)? (As purchase_frequency)

- Weekly
- Monthly
- A few times a year
- Rarely

SECTION 3: Shopping Location & Positioning

This helps with store placement decisions.

Where do you usually shop for everyday non-perishables? (As usual_nonperishable_store)

- Shopping mall
- Spaza Shop
- Bulk buying retailer
- Online stores
- Street Vendors

Which of these locations would you most likely visit for this type of store? (As preferred_location)

- CBD
- Near university
- Township (mall)
- Township shopping street
- Mall (urban)

How far would you travel to visit this store? (As travel_distance)

- Less than 10 minutes
- 10–20 minutes
- 20–30 minutes
- Only if already nearby

Do you prefer to: (As shopping_preference)

- Shop in person
- Shop online
- Both equally

SECTION 4: Branding & Approachability



Unaided:

What 3 words describe this brand? (As branding_descriptors)

Aided:

Does this brand feel: (As brand_feel)

- Approachable
- Premium
- Trendy
- Affordable
- Trustworthy
- Confusing
- Overpriced-looking
- Other

On a scale of 1–5, how approachable does this brand feel? (As approachability_score)

12345 (will be a selection scale)

Who do you think this brand is for? (As target_audience_perception)

- Teens
- Young adults
- Professionals
- Families
- Luxury buyers
- Budget shoppers

Would you feel comfortable walking into this store? (As store_comfort_feel)

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

What would make it feel more welcoming? (As store_welcome_factors)

SECTION 5: Competitive Landscape

Where do you currently shop for similar products? (As similar_products_store)

- Shoprite
- Cash and Carry
- Spaza shops
- Gwalisa
- Sopursuit
- Checkers
- Other

What do you like most about those stores? (As store_attributes)

- Affordable
- Nearby (convenience)
- Can shop online
- Quality
- Reliability

If this new store opened near you, would you switch? (As switch_intent)

- Yes
- No
- Not sure

Appendix B: Results for Market Research Undertaken

usual_nonperishable_store	preferred_location	travel_distance	shopping_preference	approachability_score	similar_products_store
Bulk buying retailer	Near university	20–30 minutes	Both	3	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	4	Checkers
Shopping mall	Near university	Less than 10 minutes	Both	3	Checkers
Shopping mall	Township (mall)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	4	Checkers
Spaza Shop	Near university	10–20 minutes	In person	3	Spaza shops
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	Both	5	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	3	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	20–30 minutes	In person	4	Shoprite
Online stores	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	Online	1	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	3	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	Both	3	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	Both	4	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	4	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	Both	5	Checkers
Bulk buying retailer	Township (mall)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	2	Checkers
Spaza Shop	CBD	20–30 minutes	In person	2	Spaza shops
Shopping mall	Near university	Less than 10 minutes	Both	2	Checkers
Bulk buying retailer	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	3	Checkers
Spaza Shop	CBD	20–30 minutes	In person	4	Cash and Carry
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	2	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	4	Checkers
Online stores	CBD	Less than 10 minutes	Both	4	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	3	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	Both	4	Checkers

usual_nonperishable_store	preferred_location	travel_distance	shopping_preference	approachability_score	similar_products_store
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	4	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Near university	10–20 minutes	In person	5	Checkers
Shopping mall	Near university	10–20 minutes	In person	4	Checkers
Online stores	Mall (urban)	20–30 minutes	Both	4	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	30+	In person	5	Shoprite
Shopping mall	CBD	30+	In person	5	Checkers
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	Less than 10 minutes	In person	2	Checkers
Shopping mall	Township (mall)	10–20 minutes	In person	3	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	20–30 minutes	In person	5	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	4	Shoprite
Shopping mall	Mall (urban)	10–20 minutes	In person	4	Checkers

branding_descriptors	target_audience_perception	store_comfort_feel	store_welcome_factors	switch_intent
Yellow, refill ,far	Budget shoppers	Yes	Branding ,colours , distance	Not sure
Affordable, Convenient and Bulk	Families	No	Customer Centric	Yes
Affordable, convenient, cheap	Budget shoppers	Not sure	Better flow	Yes
Affordable, trustworthy, reliable	Families	Yes	Friendly employees	Not sure
	Budget shoppers	Yes		Yes
Affordable, Reliable, Accommodating	Budget shoppers	Not sure	Where it's based for sure	Not sure
	Budget shoppers	Not sure		Not sure
New , Yellow, Fresh	Teens	Not sure	Social media presence	Not sure
Stokvel? Paint? Detergent?	Families	Not sure	Depends what it is.	No
Attractive, eye catching & curious	Budget shoppers	Yes	Maybe a mix of marketing that is able to target a p	Yes
Approachable, Generic, colourful	Budget shoppers	Yes		Not sure
yellow, bold, legible	Young adults	Yes	a ckean environment (ie: no spills)	Yes
Basic, low-end	Budget shoppers	Yes		Not sure
Bright, emphasis and informative	Budget shoppers	Yes	It is welcoming	Not sure
Discount affordable close to home	Budget shoppers	Yes	If i knew more information about the store	Not sure
accessible, bright, buckets	Budget shoppers	Not sure	not plastic buckets but other containers that emph	Not sure
	Families	Not sure		Not sure
Bright, Save, Stokvel	Budget shoppers	Not sure	Advertising their products and having pop-ups to pi	Not sure
Pay less everyday	Young adults	Yes		Yes
Bucket, overwhelming	Budget shoppers	Not sure	The marketing must be clear, knowing how long the	Not sure
Unique	Budget shoppers	Yes	A clean and organised environment with friendly st	Yes
	Young adults	Yes		No
Affordable,convenient, easy to shop	Budget shoppers	Not sure		Not sure

branding_descriptors	target_audience_perception	store_comfort_feel	store_welcome_factors	switch_intent
Busy, informative and elaborative	Families	Yes	Security and hygiene	Yes
Attractive brand, makes me want to rea	Families	Yes	The branding feels welcoming	No
Clear, simple and welcoming	Young adults	Yes	Security with a smile on the face	Yes
	Young adults	Yes		Yes
Sustainability, affordable	Families	Yes	Unsure what the name means, so maybe a more re	Yes
Affordable	Families	Yes	The staff members	Yes
	Young adults	Not sure	quality	Yes
Accessible, reliable, sustainable	Families	Not sure		Not sure
	Budget shoppers	Yes		Yes
Trustworthy, Transparent and Sustainat	Budget shoppers	Yes	Their quality	Yes
	Families	Yes	Affordable price	Yes
Affordable, convenient, authentic	Budget shoppers	Not sure	Friendly first impressions	Not sure

custom_quantity_interest	interest_factors	purchase_frequency	skubu_awareness	skubu_discover channel
Somewhat likely	Brand reputation	Weekly	No	Never
Somewhat likely	Quality	Weekly	No	Social media
Very likely	Convenience	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Very likely	Quality	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Somewhat likely	Convenience	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Very likely	Price	Monthly	No	
Somewhat likely	Unique products	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Somewhat likely	Quality	Monthly	No	Haven't heard
Neutral	Brand reputation	Rarely	No	Never heard of them
Neutral	Price	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Somewhat likely	Price	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Neutral	Convenience	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Very likely	Ethical/sustainable	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Somewhat likely	Quality	A few times a year	No	Never heard of them
Neutral	Price	A few times a year	Yes	Social media
Very likely	Ethical/sustainable	A few times a year	No	Never heard of them
Somewhat likely	Price	A few times a year	No	Never heard of them
Somewhat likely	Quality as well	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Very likely	Quality	A few times a year	No	Word of mouth
Neutral	Quality	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Neutral	Ethical/sustainable	Monthly	No	Never heard of them

custom_quantity_interest	interest_factors	purchase_frequency	skubu_awareness	skubu_discover channel
Neutral	Quality	Rarely	No	Never heard of them
Very likely	Price	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Very likely	Quality	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Very likely	Convenience	Monthly	No	
Neutral	Convenience	Monthly	No	Social media
Very likely	Ethical/sustainable	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Very likely	Ethical/sustainable	A few times a year	No	Never heard of them
Very likely	Convenience	Monthly	No	Social media
Very likely	Ethical/sustainable	Weekly	No	Never heard of them
Neutral	Convenience	Monthly	No	Never heard of them
Somewhat likely	Price	Monthly	Yes	Social media
Very likely	Ethical/sustainable	Monthly	Yes	News outlets
Very likely	Quality	Monthly	No	Social media
Neutral	Quality	Monthly	No	Never heard of them

Timestamp	Gender	Age	Occupation	Monthly_income	store_attributes
2026/02/26 12:30:51 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	1000 or less	Nearby (conveni
2026/02/26 12:31:56 pm EET	Male	25-30	Student	Do not wish to specify	Quality
2026/02/26 12:32:54 pm EET	Female	25-30	Student	2500 - 5000	Reliability
2026/02/26 12:33:02 pm EET	Male	18-24	Student		Affordable
2026/02/26 12:55:42 pm EET	Male	25-30	Student	5000 - 10000	Affordable
2026/02/26 1:39:17 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	2500 - 5000	Reliability
2026/02/26 1:48:45 pm EET	Female	25-30	Student	Do not wish to specify	Nearby (conveni
2026/02/26 3:05:42 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	1000 - 2500	Quality
2026/02/26 6:23:25 pm EET	Male	25-30	Working Professional (full time)	20000 or more	Quality
2026/02/26 6:38:08 pm EET	Female	18-24	Working Professional (full time)	10000 - 20000	Affordable
2026/02/26 6:43:39 pm EET	Male	18-24	Student	5000 - 10000	Quality
2026/02/26 7:25:52 pm EET	Female	18-24	Unemployed	1000 - 2500	Can shop online
2026/02/26 7:49:22 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	1000 or less	Can shop online
2026/02/26 7:51:16 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	1000 or less	Affordable
2026/02/26 7:58:09 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	Do not wish to specify	Affordable
2026/02/26 8:17:25 pm EET	Do not wish to specify	25-30	Working Professional (full time)	10000 - 20000	Quality
2026/02/26 8:50:58 pm EET	Do not wish to specify	18-24	Student	1000 - 2500	Affordable
2026/02/26 8:53:06 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	1000 or less	Quality
2026/02/26 9:11:04 pm EET	Male	25-30	Unemployed	Do not wish to specify	Affordable
2026/02/26 9:21:14 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	Do not wish to specify	Nearby (conveni
2026/02/26 9:32:41 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	Do not wish to specify	Nearby (conveni

Timestamp	Gender	Age	Occupation	Monthly_income	store_attributes
2026/02/26 10:13:04 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	1000 or less	Affordable
2026/02/27 7:45:13 am EET	Female	25-30	Working professional (part time)	1000 or less	Nearby (conveni
2026/02/27 7:58:24 am EET	Male	25-30	Working Professional (full time)	20000 or more	Quality
2026/02/27 11:43:38 am EET	Female	18-24	Student	2500 - 5000	Affordable
2026/02/27 4:18:37 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	Do not wish to specify	Quality
2026/02/27 6:24:24 pm EET	Female	18-24	Unemployed	1000 or less	Quality
2026/02/28 3:57:22 pm EET	Do not wish to specify	25-30	Working Professional (full time)	10000 - 20000	Can shop online
2026/03/02 4:28:31 pm EET	Female	18-24	Working professional (part time)	1000 or less	Affordable
2026/03/02 4:46:20 pm EET	Female	18-24	Student	Do not wish to specify	Quality
2026/03/02 5:15:57 pm EET	Female	18-24	Self-employed	2500 - 5000	Nearby (conveni
2026/03/02 6:03:54 pm EET	Male	18-24	Freelancer	Do not wish to specify	Nearby (conveni
2026/03/03 12:19:26 am EET	Female	18-24	Unemployed	Do not wish to specify	Nearby (conveni
2026/03/03 4:46:55 am EET	Female	51-60	Self-employed	2500 - 5000	Affordable
2026/03/08 10:20:32 am EET	Female	25-30	Working Professional (full time)	5000 - 10000	Quality